

Sony Ericsson S500i

Not everyone will set themselves a budget as high as Rs 25K for a phone. Most of us Diwali shoppers will look for more mid-range phones... so we decided to recommend something new, something that will let your purchase stand out from the crowd. Sony Ericsson launched the S500i in the beginning of October, and at first glance, this phone looks really cool. Of the four colours available—Mysterious Green, Ice Purple, Contrasted Copper and Spring Yellow—our favourites are the first two. The phone is a slider; the 2-inch TFT display works at 240 x 320, with 262K colours. It's EDGE-capable, has quad-band GSM capability and supports Bluetooth (A2DP stereo, for wireless headphones). The phone weighs just 92 gm, and is 14 mm thick. Onboard memory is scarce—just 12 MB—but you can upgrade to 2 GB using the Memory Stick Micro (M2) slot. The phone features Sony's Walkman software for phones, so your music experience will be good. The 2MP camera offers decent pictures, and is on par with other phones in this range. The buttons are small, but well-designed and tactile enough. Talk time is 9 hours and standby time is 370 hours. The menu is exciting to play with, and Sony Ericsson says, "...S500i keeps you in harmony with the world around you. Let desktop and menu themes change with the season; or as day turns to night." So your phone menu looks different on different days and even changes between day and night! You can personalise the phone's "light effects"—the way the phone lights up when a call comes through. In terms of specs, the phone is quite what you'd expect for the price—nothing extraordinary. However, if you'd like to make a style statement with your phone, the S500i can be the centre of attention... if you want it to be.



Cameras

From semi-professional to point-and-click



Sony Cyber-shot DSC W200

For those of you on a smaller budget, or if you just want a pocketable camera that gives you great quality and ease of use, we recommend the DSC W200. This Cyber-shot camera from Sony is really compact for its 12MP rating. The DSC W200 features Sony's Super SteadyShot optical image stabilisation technology, face detection and 9-point autofocus. This translates to an easy to use camera that very rarely gives you blurry shots. Video capture is possible at 30 fps VGA. The camera has a Carl Zeiss lens with 3x optical zoom, which provides good results in well-lit scenarios. At 142 gm, the camera is as light as you'd expect it to be, but still feels good and steady in your hands. The design also helps you get a good grip of the thing when you're shooting, and coupled with the image stabilisation software you're not likely to get motion blurs. Apart from standard USB and AV connectors, the camera features a HD output jack, so you can hook it up directly to your HDTV. Software running on the camera lets you set up slide-shows for viewing on your HDTV. The DSC W200 is available at quite a varied price—between Rs 13,000 and Rs 16,000—because some dealers sell only the camera, some sell it with a carry pouch, and some even throw in a 2 GB Memory Stick Pro Duo.

Nikon D40x

The D40x is our personal favourite camera. We suggest you use this as a benchmark for other "Diwali offers" you might find. This is a 10.2MP camera that seems to fit perfectly in your hands. It's light—a mere 495 gm without the battery. Even professional photographers have showered praises on the camera's image quality at its low price. The D40x is in India available for around Rs 29,000. We should warn you that the older D40 (6.1MP) is also still being sold in India for around Rs 22,000, so make sure you don't get confused between the D40 and D40x. Although the older D40 is a very good camera in itself, the D40x comes with an 18-55 mm Nikkor lens bundled, so it's actually a way better deal. The D40x uses SD memory cards to store pictures, which is good because SD flash memory prices are plummeting. The camera features auto white balance, Nikon's



Multi-CAM 530 autofocus technology, five shooting modes, Nikon's 3D Color Matrix Metering II exposure control system, and a lot of shooting controls to give you a perfectly exposed and timed picture. Shutter speeds range from 30 to 1/4000. The pop-up flash is good for indoor-low-light shooting. The D40x uses a custom Li-ion battery that has a decent life, but shutterbugs who shoot in excess of 500 pics on a single charge might need a spare battery. Overall, any semi-professional shooter would be quite happy with this camera.